

not enlist simply to protect the flag, the Constitution, or hearth and home. Northern Germans and Irish especially wanted to “prove” their worthiness as adopted citizens by volunteering and believed that in doing so, they might eliminate lingering nativistic, anti-immigrant trends in Northern society. In the 1850s the Know-Nothing Party rose briefly to national prominence on a platform devoted to political war on the foreign-born. However, the sentiments they unleashed died hard, and ethnic Americans were eager to do something important in the war to overcome their fellow-citizens’ fear of foreigners.

By the end of 1861 an entire division of German-born troops, composed of German-speaking regiments from New York, Ohio, and Pennsylvania, was placed under the command of Brigadier General Ludwig Blenker in the defenses of Washington, D.C. Around the same time, the Irish formed the soon-to-be-famous Irish Brigade, under the command of Irish nationalist Thomas Francis Meagher, and the Irish Legion, led by Michael Corcoran.

The majority of ethnic soldiers—approximately 70 percent—served in “mixed” regiments composed both of immigrants and native-born Americans, but the spotlight quickly fell on the ethnic regiments as their political leaders boasted of their inherent martial abilities compared to the “American farmboys.” It helped that the majority of German recruits had seen military service or even fought as revolutionaries at some point before coming to the United States, as had a fair number of the Irish.